

VANCE SAYS NO RETURN TO WAR UNLESS NEEDED

Technical talks kick off; ‘We are getting along well’: Trump

Iran prioritising release of frozen assets, Hormuz remains in focus

Reuters

Washington, Dubai, Doha
July 1

US VICE President JD Vance said discussions between the US and Iran were going well as they held indirect technical talks in Qatar about the Strait of Hormuz on Wednesday, adding Washington would not return to full combat unless necessary.

The talks are based on a 14-point interim accord signed last month that was meant to halt the war that began with US-Israeli strikes on Iran in February and reopen the strait, while setting up 60 days of negotiations for a permanent peace deal.

However, the US and Iran have sparred publicly over the meaning of the interim pact, leading to tit-for-tat military strikes over the past week and leaving little sign of progress on more complex issues, including on Iran's nuclear programme.

Vance said he could not guarantee that Washington would not return to full combat operations ahead of next month's deadline but that for now Presi-



An Ultra-Orthodox Jewish man poses for a photo at a memorial site on the border with Lebanon in northern Israel, on Wednesday. AP

dent Donald Trump had directed officials to make a deal.

“I can't commit to anything, because obviously it depends on what the Iranians are ultimately going to do,” he told reporters on a visit to Virginia Beach, Virginia. “What I can commit to is: The president's not going to send our military back in unless he has to, unless there's a clearly defined purpose for it.”

In Doha, technical talks were focused on commercial shipping in the strait and would later turn to Tehran's nuclear capabilities, Vance said, adding: “It's still pretty early, but talks are going well.”

Iran is determined to win international recognition of its control over the key oil-shipping

waterway and its ability to levy fees on ships entering or leaving the Gulf, even if it has to do so by force, according to two senior Iranian sources. Trump, who has said removing Iran's highly enriched uranium is a top priority, told reporters on Wednesday that “the denuclearization of Iran is moving along well”, without giving details.

Asked about the possibility of returning to all-out war with Iran, Trump added: “Well, I think they've come a long way. We hit them very hard last week. I think they're fine.”

The indirect talks, mediated by Qatar and Pakistan, began on Tuesday night and were continuing on Wednesday, an Iranian official said.

Unchecked AI progress may pose catastrophic risks, warns UN panel

Reuters

Geneva, July 1

DEVELOPMENTS IN artificial intelligence are outpacing scientific understanding and government policy, meaning there are no guarantees technology will not cause catastrophic harm, a United Nations independent panel warned on Wednesday.

A preliminary report by the UN's Independent International Scientific Panel on Artificial Intelligence said policymakers face a growing dilemma: they need robust evidence to regulate AI effectively, yet such evidence is struggling to keep pace with technology's rapid evolution.

“AI capabilities are outpacing both scientific understanding and governments' ability to adapt,” said Yoshua Bengio, co-chair of the panel, comprised of 40 cross-regional experts.

“With growing evidence of deceptive AI behaviour, science currently cannot guarantee that as capabilities continue to increase, AI will not cause catastrophic harm”

YOSHUA BENGIO,
CO-CHAIR

“With growing evidence of deceptive AI behaviour, science currently cannot guarantee that as capabilities continue to increase, AI will not cause catastrophic harm, either on its own or due to malicious users.”

Described as the first global

independent assessment of AI's risks and opportunities, the report aims to give up-to-date evaluations of the science to help guide decision-making as governments contend with fast-evolving systems.

In the near term, it expects a shift towards agentic AI systems capable of carrying out real-world tasks, although growth may be constrained by energy and high-quality data shortages.

Over time, it foresees self-improving AI embedded more deeply in the economy and converging with technologies such as quantum computing and biotechnology. AI already demonstrates expert-level reasoning in mathematics and science and is accelerating drug and vaccine development, potentially allowing systems to complete work that takes humans days or weeks, according to the report.

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GOVT NOTIFIES MEASURES: NON-BS VI VEHICLES REGISTERED OUTSIDE DELHI TO BE BARRED

Vehicle, construction curbs, WFH: Delhi moves to combat winter haze

Restrictions to be mandatory from Nov 1 to Feb 28, will operate with GRAP

Sophiya Mathew & Devansh Mittal
New Delhi, July 1

IN A move to combat air pollution during the winter months, the Delhi government has notified a series of restrictions that will come into force from No-

vember 1 to February 28 every year — from curbs on vehicles and construction activities, to staggered office timings and work from home.

Until now, the practice was to impose various stages of the Graded Response Action Plan (GRAP), depending on the air quality index (AQI), during these months. The implementation of GRAP — a framework mechanism under which the governments in Delhi and the National Capital Region (NCR) must take specific sets of actions — is overseen by the Commission for Air Quality Man-

agement (CAQM).

But with the new restrictions, notified on June 23 and made public on Wednesday, many of the measures will mandatorily come into force during this period. These restrictions are set to operate alongside GRAP.

This could tackle two key concerns. The move seeks to reduce disruptions to workplaces, educational institutions and transport through advance planning while addressing long-standing criticism that pollution-control restrictions

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

•KEY MEASURES

FUEL ONLY to vehicles with valid PUC through the year.

ENTRY OF non-Delhi registered vehicles below BS-VI barred from Nov 1-Jan 31.

50% PHYSICAL attendance in govt, pvt offices from Nov 1-Jan 31.

BAN ON most demolition, dust-generating construction work from Nov 1-Jan 31.

COMPLETE BAN on construction, demolition from Dec 10-Jan 20, barring urgent govt projects.



ANTI-SMOG guns/mist systems mandatory for commercial buildings exceeding 3,000 sq m.

RWAs, HOUSING societies, institutions, contractors responsible for preventing open burning of waste, leaves, biomass and garbage.

ON THREE-DAY INDIA VISIT, WILL HOLD TALKS WITH MODI TODAY



Japanese Prime Minister Sanae Takaichi arrives in New Delhi, Wednesday. @TAKAICHI_SANAE/X

Tokyo, Delhi to deepen strategic ties, Takaichi flags global uncertainty

Chips, rare earth, supply chains on table; large Japan business delegation too here

Divya A
New Delhi, July 1

UNDERLINING THAT she intends to deepen her country's strategic ties with India in this time of "growing uncertainty in the international situation", Japan's Prime Minister Sanae Takaichi reached New Delhi Wednesday evening on a three-day visit, her first to India after entering office last year.

Soon after Takaichi's arrival, Prime Minister Narendra Modi,

in a post on X, said, "We are delighted to host you on your first visit to India and I look forward to our wide-ranging discussions tomorrow that will further deepen the India-Japan Special Strategic and Global Partnership."

"Through our joint efforts, we will continue to advance peace, stability and prosperity in the Indo-Pacific and beyond," Modi said.

Received at Delhi airport by

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

E. EXPLAINED

Special partnership

India and Japan upgraded their ties to a Special Strategic and Global Partnership in 2014. During PM Narendra Modi's visit to Japan last year, the two sides had charted a roadmap for the next decade, raising the Japanese investment target in India to 10 trillion yen, launching initiatives on economic security cooperation, digital partnership & AI.

NEED OF THE HOUR: REKHA GUPTA

Delhi CM offers: Can cut House term for simultaneous polls

Parliamentary panel on ONOE Bills also meets Speaker and Lt Governor



P P Chaudhary, chairperson of Parliamentary panel on joint polls, with Delhi CM Rekha Gupta in New Delhi, Wednesday. ANI

Damini Nath & Jatinder Anand
New Delhi, July 1

DESCRIBING THE concept of One Nation One Election as "the need of the hour", Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta Wednesday told the Joint Committee of Parliament on Bills relating to simultaneous elections that her government would be willing to consider adjusting the tenure of the Delhi Assembly to align with that of the Lok Sabha. She pointed to cutting short the Assembly's term which currently ends eight months after that of Lok Sabha.

The committee, chaired by

BJP MP P P Chaudhary, conducted a study visit in the Capital, meeting the Chief Minister at the Delhi Secretariat, Speaker Vijender Gupta and representatives of parties at the Assembly and Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu at Lok Niwas.

In a statement, the Chief Minister's Office said: "Referring to Delhi, she (Gupta) pointed out that elections in the national Capital are held roughly a year apart from the Lok Sabha elections. If aligning election schedules at the national level requires a suitable

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

AHEAD OF MONSOON SESSION

Bill clause for removal of ministers in custody for 30 days likely to be retained in panel report

Opp members of panel expected to submit dissent note on report

Liz Mathew
New Delhi, July 1

THE JOINT Committee of Parliament, examining the 130th Constitution Amendment Bill that seeks to remove ministers detained for serious offences for 30 consecutive days, is expected

to adopt its report on July 17. A House panel adopting a report is a routine procedure before a Bill is tabled in Parliament.

While the report is likely to retain the contentious clause that proposes the automatic removal of the Prime Minister, Chief Ministers, or other ministers from office if they are arrested and detained in custody for 30 consecutive days for serious offences, there could be notes of caution to ensure that the law is not misused for political vendetta, sources said.

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

ISSUES NOTICE, GIVES COMPANY THREE DAYS TO RESPOND

Impersonation concerns, don't roll out 'username' feature: Govt to WhatsApp

Soumyarendra Barik
New Delhi, July 1

THE GOVERNMENT has issued a notice to Meta-owned WhatsApp on the planned roll-out of the messaging service's 'username' feature over concerns of impersonation and fraud and directed the company not to roll it out until a thorough

consultation on the subject, *The Indian Express* has learnt.

Earlier this week, WhatsApp announced it would gradually allow users to select a username and hide their phone numbers when contacting another user for the first time. It is an optional unique identifier a user can choose for her WhatsApp account. It can also

be used by others to message or call her, while keeping the phone number private.

Senior government officials said the Union Ministry of Home Affairs raised concerns with the Ministry of Electronics and IT. They said the government would undertake a risk assessment of the new feature.

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[FROM PAGE 1 | FULL REPORTS ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM]

Delhi pollution

under GRAP are largely reactive as they are implemented as air quality deteriorates.

The notification said the framework was based on an analysis of air quality trends over the past three winter seasons, which showed that Delhi's air quality consistently deteriorated between November 1 and February 15. During these months in 2023-24, 2024-25, and 2025-26, the city's median AQI ranged between 312 and 342 ('very poor'), while the peak AQI ranged between 461 and 494 ('severe+').

According to the new restrictions, motor vehicles registered outside Delhi and below BS-VI emission standards will not be allowed to ply in the national capital from November 1 to January 31 every year. This will not apply to CNG and EVs, emergency services such as ambulances, fire tenders and police vehicles, and other categories specifically exempted by the environment department.

"All motor vehicles registered outside the National Capital Ter-

ritory of Delhi and below BS-VI emission standards shall not be permitted to ply in Delhi," says the notification. All petrol, diesel and CNG/LPG retail outlets across Delhi will supply fuel only on production of a valid PUC throughout the year.

To discourage the use of private vehicles, parking charges at authorised parking sites will be doubled from November 1 to February 28. Parking facilities owned and managed by DMRC have been exempted.

Measures such as staggered office timings and work from home have also been taken to reduce traffic congestion. From November 1 to February 28, offices under the MCD will function from 8.30 am to 5 pm, while Delhi government offices will operate from 10 am to 6.30 pm.

From November 1 to January 31, Delhi government and private offices will function with no more than 50% physical staff attendance, while the remaining employees will work from home.

Essential and emergency ser-

vices, including hospitals, public transport, power, water supply, sanitation, disaster management and pollution-control agencies, have been exempted.

"All private entities are to... implement staggered working hours, ensure strict compliance with work-from-home norms, minimise vehicular movement associated with office commute by using methods like car-pooling, ride-sharing, common bus, promoting public transport etc," says the notification.

Also, from November 1 to January 31, there will be a ban on dust-generating demolition and open civil construction activities, except for essential public infrastructure projects. A complete ban on construction and demolition activities, barring urgent government projects and emergency works, will remain in force from December 10 to January 20.

During the same period, vehicles carrying construction material such as sand, stone, bricks, cement and debris will not be allowed to enter Delhi, except those engaged in projects of national importance, essential public infrastructure, emerg-

ency works and other exempted categories. The notification also mandates anti-smog guns or mist systems for large commercial buildings and construction sites above specified sizes.

To tackle open burning, the notification makes RWAs, housing societies, institutions, contractors and establishments responsible for preventing burning of waste, biomass, leaves, garbage and plastic within areas under their control.

Typically, under GRAP Stage I, when AQI ranges between 201-300, measures taken include intensified enforcement of dust-control measures and stricter checks on vehicular emissions.

Stage II (AQI 301-400) adds restrictions on diesel generators and increases road sweeping and water sprinkling. Stage III (AQI 401-450) bans non-essential construction and demolition activities and restricts plying of certain categories of vehicles. Stage IV (AQI above 450) brings the strictest curbs, including a ban on truck entry except essential services, school closure and suspension of non-essential construction.

Japan

Minister of State Jitendra Singh, Takaichi said, "In discussions with PM Modi, centering on urgent issues including economic security and energy security, we will aim to deepen the strategic cooperative relationship between Japan and India in light of the current international situation, promote mutually complementary cooperation, and further strengthen the Japan-India 'Special Strategic Global Partnership'."

With economic security as the overarching theme, Takaichi's visit is expected to boost investment and innovation opportunities, and help build resilient supply chains in areas such as semiconductors and critical minerals.

According to the MEA, Takaichi will take part in the 16th India-Japan Annual Summit, a mechanism established in 2006 under which the PMs of the two countries meet annually.

Japan's Ministry of Foreign Affairs said the visit will "strengthen relations with India, which is of utmost importance for the realisation of a Free and Open Indo-Pacific". Delhi and Tokyo share a deep strategic convergence on a free and open Indo-Pacific, driven by mutual interests amid China's growing assertions in the region.

At an informal press conference in Tokyo before leaving for Delhi, Takaichi said she intends to "advance concrete cooperation" with Modi.

"At a time when the international situation is becoming increasingly uncertain, cooperation with India, which shares fundamental values and strategic interests with Japan, is becoming more important than

ever," she said, according to the Japanese PMO.

"Through this visit, I hope to advance concrete cooperation with Prime Minister Modi in three key areas: deepening the Japan-India strategic partnership in light of the current international situation; promoting cooperation in economic security; and strengthening collaboration between businesses of our two countries in investment and innovation," she said.

Diplomatic sources said the focus during Takaichi's visit will also be on boosting maritime security, defence technology cooperation, and developing an 'Industrial Value Chain' connecting the Bay of Bengal with North-East India.

India and Japan are also expected to make progress on energy security and in tackling supply chain disruptions in the wake of the West Asia crisis.

The summit follows Modi's visit to Tokyo in August 2025 for the 15th edition, during which the two countries reaffirmed their commitment to deepen cooperation across strategic, economic, technological and security domains.

A large business delegation is accompanying Takaichi, and the two PMs will also attend business events with executives from both countries. According to government statistics, around 1,400 Japanese companies operate in India, with nearly half of them in manufacturing sector.

A Japan-India Economic Forum is also scheduled after delegation-level talks Thursday, with the participation of more than 150 individuals from Japan's business community. "Working together with the private sector, I hope to broaden the scope of Japan-India cooperation and realize a strong economy," Takaichi said.

Joint polls

adjustment in Delhi's tenure, the Delhi Government is willing to consider it with a positive approach. If required in the national interest, she said, Delhi could be among the leading states to extend such cooperation."

The next LS elections are likely in April-June 2029, as the term of the House ends on June 23, 2029, while the Delhi Assembly's term ends on February 23, 2030. Since its formation in De-

cember 2024, the committee has held consultations with stakeholders in Delhi and visited several states.

Reached for comment, Chaudhary said the meetings Wednesday were productive. "We have asked the Chief Secretary to prepare a report on the impact of frequent elections on different sectors like education and labour," he said.

While the Bills in their current form provide for the first simultaneous elections in 2034 by cutting short the terms of all Assemblies elected after the LS elections of 2029, Chaudhary,

speaking at the Idea Exchange programme of *The Indian Express* recently, that if some states want, they can curtail the terms of their Assemblies to align with the 2029 elections too.

According to the CMO statement, the CM said One Nation One Election was the need of the hour. A statement from Assembly Secretariat said Speaker Vijender Gupta made suggestions to the committee during their meeting, including conducting a "comprehensive examination of issues relating to the synchronisation of electoral cycles, constructive votes of no-confi-

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dence, premature dissolution of legislatures, harmonisation of electoral rolls, strengthening the logistical preparedness of the Election Commission, and institutional mechanisms to ensure political stability while preserving India's democratic and federal character." It is learnt that during the meeting with the Speaker and MLAs, it was suggested to create a national forum with representation from each Legislative Assembly to discuss the way forward and the need to extend the provisions of One Nation One Election to RS and municipal body polls.

Bill

The Bill will be taken up in the Monsoon Session of Parliament, likely to begin on July 20, for consideration and passage, sources said.

Union Home Minister Amit Shah introduced the Bill in August last year, and a 31-member parliamentary panel, chaired by BJP MP Aparajita Sarangi, was formed to examine it.

Most members of the panel from the INDIA opposition bloc, including from the Congress, boycotted the proceedings, arguing that participation was pointless as the ruling party would override the opposition's concerns and use the panel as a rubber stamp to clear the Bill.

Members of the panel belonging to the ruling coalition, it is learnt, rejected the opposition's argument that the provisions in the proposed law are undemocratic, anti-federal and contradict the bedrock principle of natural justice by punishing public representative-spurely based on custody rather than conviction.

The treasury benches, it is learnt, argue 30 days are enough to seek bail at least thrice and, therefore, the legislation does not violate the principle of natural justice.

However, the panel's members — be it from ruling coalition, the opposition and neutral parties — are convinced that the draft Bill should add provisions to avoid misuse of the law, sources said. The committee is also expected to recommend curbs or a threshold regarding the nature of the crime for provisions of the proposed law to apply.

Opposition MPs on the parliamentary panel are likely to give a dissent note on the report, sources said.

WhatsApp

and see if it falls foul of the current legal architecture.

The government has asked Meta to furnish a detailed explanation on the username feature in the next three days, and has directed the company to not roll out the feature until consultation on the matter is over, an official said.

"As we understand now, there is a possibility that bad actors may claim usernames, or close-enough variations related to prominent personalities, institutions, and organisations, and message other users while pretending to be someone they are not. For those who may not be technologically aware to make out the difference, it could be a huge challenge. We have already seen bad actors carry out impersonation-linked scams such as digital arrests through WhatsApp, and this feature could further help them," a senior government official said, requesting anonymity.

In a statement, WhatsApp said it plans to roll out the features slowly later this year, but clarified it has built safeguards. "To protect against impersonation, we've held the highest-profile names — think public figures, government entities, celebrities, verified Meta accounts — so they can only ever be claimed by their legitimate owners and lookalike derivatives of known names are held as well."

It said users still require a phone number to use WhatsApp and that it has built multiple layers of defense against scams into usernames. "Other users need to know the exact username to message you, we will limit how many new people an account can contact, block repeated attempts to guess someone's username key, and have

systems to detect and remove activity showing common impersonation and abuse patterns," the WhatsApp spokesperson said.

Further, it said, when the feature becomes available and someone sends a message for the first time via the username, WhatsApp will show if they are a new account, if they are in contact, if they are in common groups, and if they are based in a different country, so that one can choose whether to respond or not, the spokesperson said.

Another government official said that during internal assessments and subsequent questioning of WhatsApp, if they do not think there are enough guardrails to protect against impersonation, the government may also look into whether the feature's rollout should be stopped altogether. Queries sent to the ministries of IT and Home Affairs remained unanswered until publication.

Paytm founder and CEO Vijay Shekhar Sharma has warned that look-alike usernames could become a major vector for impersonation and scams if not properly protected. "Soon you will have verified username on WhatsApp, and then unverified similar-sounding usernames," he said on X.

Mobikwik's CEO Bipin Preet Singh said on X, "Not a good idea at all. Will lead to proliferation of fraud and impersonation."

The feature has not been yet rolled out. "WhatsApp takes impersonation and abuse seriously. If you think someone is pretending to be you or someone else on WhatsApp in order to scam other WhatsApp users, or attempting to buy, sell, or trade WhatsApp usernames, you should report the user and any suspicious messages so we can review and take action to protect our users," WhatsApp said in an update on its help centre.



Rs 300-450: Govt rolls out rural job scheme in new avatar, notifies wages

Harikishan Sharma
New Delhi, July 1

THE CENTRE has notified wage rates for unskilled manual workers under the Viiksit Bharat-Guarantee for Rozgar and Ajeevika Mission (Gramin) (VB-G RAM G) Act, 2025, which came into effect on Tuesday, replacing the two-decade-old Mahatma Gandhi National Rural Employment Guarantee Act (MGNREGA), 2005.

Daily wages have been fixed between Rs 300 and Rs 409 across states, with a special rate of Rs 450 in certain gram panchayats in Sikkim, as per a notification issued by the Union Ministry of Rural Development late Tuesday night.

Northern and northeastern states such as Arunachal Pradesh, Nagaland, Himachal Pradesh, Uttar Pradesh, Uttarakhand, Bihar, Jharkhand, Assam, Tripura, Sikkim and West Bengal have seen wage hikes of over 15%. Haryana, which has the highest wage rate of Rs 409, stands out with the lowest hike of just 2.25%.

Southern states like Karnataka, Tamil Nadu, Andhra Pradesh and Telangana saw a hike of 3% or below.

The new wage rates

The wage rate has been fixed at Rs 300 for 21 states: Gujarat, Manipur, Mizoram, Rajasthan, Odisha, Jammu and Kashmir, Ladakh, Meghalaya, Chhattisgarh, Madhya Pradesh, West Bengal, Sikkim, Assam, Tripura, Free Whatsapp Channel <https://whatsapp.com/channel/0029Van2VRb6RGJOKH6oBd0F>

•HIKE IN WAGES: TOP 10 STATES

State/UT	MGNREGA wages			VB G RAM G wages (Rs/day)	Increase (in %)#
	2024-25	2025-26	Increase (in %)		
Arunachal Pradesh	234	241	2.99	300	24.48
Nagaland	234	241	2.99	300	24.48
Himachal Pradesh*	236	247	4.66	300	21.46
Uttar Pradesh	237	252	6.33	300	19.05
Uttarakhand	237	252	6.33	300	19.05
Bihar	245	255	4.08	300	17.65
Jharkhand	245	255	4.08	300	17.65
Assam	249	256	2.81	300	17.19
Tripura	242	256	5.79	300	17.19
Sikkim	249	259	4.02	300	15.83

*(Non-scheduled areas) # for FY 27 in VB G RAM G wages; Source: notifications for respective years

Free Telegram Channel https://t.me/+2RvD_RGf9mljMzg1 and Lachen -- will pay a fixed wage rate of Rs 450.

Bihar, Jharkhand, Uttar Pradesh, Uttarakhand, Himachal Pradesh (non-scheduled areas), Arunachal Pradesh and Nagaland.

The wage rates for the other states have been fixed as follows: Rs 308 for Telangana, Rs 312 for Andhra Pradesh, Rs 317 for Maharashtra, Rs 340 for Dadra and Nagar Haveli and Daman and Diu, Rs 345 for Tamil Nadu, Rs 347 for Puducherry, Rs 348 for Andaman and Nicobar (Andaman District) and Lakshadweep, Rs 360 for Punjab, Rs 367 for Andaman and Nicobar (Nicobar District), Rs 375 for Himachal Pradesh (scheduled areas), Rs 382 for Karnataka, Rs 401 for Kerala, and Rs 406 for Goa.

Three gram panchayats in Sikkim -- Gnathang, Lachung

and Lachen -- will pay a fixed wage rate of Rs 450.

Why 'hike' not a hike

While the wage rates notified under the VB-G RAM G Act appear higher than the prevailing MGNREGA wages, it is because the government had not increased MGNREGA wages for 2026-27. The Centre last notified the MGNREGA wages on March 27 last year, which were applicable for the 2025-26 financial year, and continued with it during the first quarter (April-June) of the current fiscal year (2026-27). If the Centre had increased MGNREGA wages for the current financial year, the hike in VB-G RAM G wages would have been more or less the same.

Section 10 of the VB-G RAM G Act empowers the Centre to specify wage rates for unskilled manual work provided under the Scheme. As per the Act, the Central government can notify different wage rates for different areas. The Act also mandates that the wage rate notified under the VB-G RAM G law shall not be less than the prevailing wage rate as notified under Section 6 of the MGNREGA, 2005.

How are wages fixed

The VB-G RAM G Act provides for the notification of different wage rates for different areas. Although the notification issued by the Union Ministry of Rural Development does not spell out the methodology used to determine the state-wise wage rates, it is understood that the Ministry adopted the prevailing MGNREGA wage rates as the basis.

Consequently, states such as Haryana, Goa and Kerala, which already had relatively high MGNREGA wage rates, have been assigned correspondingly higher wages under the VB-G RAM G Act, exceeding Rs 400 per day in all three states.

The Act further stipulates that the wage rate notified under the VB-G RAM G Act cannot be lower than the prevailing wage rate notified under Section 6 of the MGNREGA, 2005. It also provides that, until the Central government notifies wage rates under the new law, the wage rates notified under the MGNREGA will continue to apply.

This can be traced to the methodology adopted by the Rural Development Ministry for fixing state-wise wages.

When NREGA was enacted, it stipulated that wages could not be less than Rs 60 per day. It also provided that, until the Centre notified a wage rate for a particular area, the minimum wage for agricultural labourers fixed by the respective state governments under Section 3 of the Minimum Wages Act, 1948, would apply.

As a result, states such as Haryana, where the statutory minimum wage for agricultural labourers was already higher than Rs 60 per day, offered higher wages under the MGNREGA.

Subsequently, when the government linked MGNREGA wage revisions to the Consumer Price Index for Agricultural Labourers (CPI-AL) and established a minimum wage floor of Rs 100 per day, these states retained their wage advantage.

Consequently, Haryana has continued to record one of the highest wage rates under the rural employment guarantee scheme.

Low hikes for South

The lower hike in percentage terms for southern states may be because of two reasons. First, the base effect: these states already have high wage rates in absolute terms. Second, as VB-G RAM G wages have been fixed after taking into account the current MGNREGA wages and inflation, the regional variation is obvious.

Gen Dhiraj Seth takes over as Army Chief, unveils ‘VIJAY’ roadmap

Amrita Nayak Dutta
New Delhi, July 1

ASSUMING CHARGE as the 31st Chief of Army Staff on Wednesday, General Dhiraj Seth underlined the need to take forward the modernisation of the Army with “renewed energy and firm resolve to respond effectively to the evolving security environment.” He said the aim is to build a technology-enabled, future-ready Army “which is fully empowered and capable of operating across multiple domains.”

Stating that the Army is a combat-ready and battle-hardened force, fully prepared and capable of meeting every challenge in the operational domain, he listed his focus areas in the acronym ‘VIJAY’, of which ‘V’ stands for Vigilance along borders and against emerging threats.

Gen Seth said that ‘I’ stands for Innovation and Transformation and that his focus will be on innovation in both doctrine and technological solutions. “Innovation will remain an integral part of our thinking, our systems and our capability development. At the same time, necessary transformations will be undertaken in keeping with the changing character of warfare.”

‘J’ stands for Jointness and Integration, Gen Seth said, adding that to enhance the operational effectiveness of the Indian Army, “we will maintain complete synergy and coordination with the Indian Air Force and the Indian Navy”.

“I fully recognise that national security is not limited to military strength alone. It requires military-civil fusion and a whole-of-nation approach. This integrated approach will also enable us to contribute meaningfully to nation building and to the goal of

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Chief of Army Staff Gen Dhiraj Seth inspects the guard of honour in New Delhi on Wednesday. TASHI TOBGYAL
Free Whatsapp Channel <https://whatsapp.com/channel/0029Van2VRb6RGJOKH6oBd0F>
Viksit Bharat 2047.”

He further said that ‘A’ stands for Atmanirbharta and, with indigenous capabilities and technologies developed within the country, there is a need to build a self-reliant Army. He said the overall aim will be: “To win our wars with indigenous solutions.”

Lastly, he said ‘Y’ stands for Yodha First, adding that from the Agniveer to the senior-most veteran, each army personnel is a yodha (fighter). “These yodhas are the greatest strength of our Army. Enhancing the technological threshold and training standards of our soldiers will be among my foremost priorities. Our veterans and Veer Naris are an integral part of the Army family, and their welfare, empowerment and professional growth will remain extremely important to me,” he said.

“I assure every citizen of the country that the Indian Army is, and will always remain, fully prepared to protect the sovereignty, territorial integrity and national interests of our nation,” Gen Seth said in his address.

In leadership reshuffle, CISC and Vice-Chiefs take charge

Amrita Nayak Dutta
New Delhi, July 1

SENIOR INDIAN military leadership Wednesday saw a series of changes with top officers of the Army and Air Force taking over critical appointments in the Armed Forces.

General Dhiraj Seth took over as the 31st Chief of Army Staff. He is the third Army Chief from the 2nd Lancers, one of the oldest armoured regiments in the country, and the first Armoured Corps officer to be appointed as the Army Chief in the last 30 years after General Shankar Roy Chowdhury (1994-97).

Air Marshal Ashutosh Dixit, who has been serving as the Chief of Integrated Defence Staff (CISC), took over as the Vice-Chief of the Air Staff after the retirement of Air Marshal Nagesh Kapoor.

Commissioned into the

fighter stream of the IAF on December 6, 1986, Air Marshal Dixit has extensive flying experience on various aircraft such as the Mirage-2000, variants of MiGs, HPT-32, An-32, Avro, Kiran, Jaguar, IL-78, Hawk and Tejas.

He is an Experimental Test Pilot and a Qualified Flying Instructor and has been actively involved in numerous operations and exercises such as Op Safed Sagar, Op Rakshak, Cope India and Op Sindoor.

On Wednesday, Lt Gen Sandeep Jain, formerly the Southern Army Commander, also took charge as the Army’s Vice-Chief; while Air Marshal Tejinder Singh became the new CISC.

Additionally, Lt Gen Mohit Malhotra and Lt Gen Rajesh Pushkar assumed command of the Army’s Jaipur-based South Western Command and the Pune-based Southern Command.

Fresh ethnic tension in two Manipur villages

FRESH ETHNIC tensions gripped the Indo-Myanmar border in Kamjong district of Manipur on Wednesday after armed miscreants attacked two villages, police said. Police said unidentified miscreants arrived at Phaimol Kuki village around 12:30 pm and torched all the houses, sparing the church. The attack on Phaimol Kuki village triggered retaliatory violence, with another group targeting Shangkhak Tangkhul village barely an hour later. No casualties have been reported. ENS

As US reshapes its Asia strategy, India must rewire its regional leadership

Signs of resilience, but risks need monitoring

IN THE fourth quarter of the last financial year, the Indian economy grew at a healthy pace, despite widespread disruptions to energy markets and global trade in March due to the West Asia conflict. In the months thereafter, even as the conflict dragged on, some of the high-frequency indicators suggest that the economic momentum has sustained to an extent. This is evident in e-way bill generation, PMI indices and electricity consumption, as the finance ministry’s latest monthly economic review points out. However, as the report also notes, there are some signs of moderation. For instance, the index of eight core industries grew by just 1.1 per cent during April-May.

India entered this crisis with high growth, low inflation and strong bank and corporate balance sheets. These, as RBI Governor Sanjay Malhotra notes in the latest financial stability report, have “helped preserve macro-financial stability”. The health of the financial system can be gauged across a range of indicators. Banks have seen a decline in bad loans — gross NPAs were at 1.8 per cent in March 2026, there were no signs of any build-up in stress. Their capital position remained comfortable — capital to risk weighted assets ratio was at 17.7 per cent — the liquidity buffers were strong and profitability indicators stable. In fact, the stress tests conducted by the central bank suggest that banks can cope with adverse shocks. Funding, though, is a challenge. Similarly, the corporate sector also appears to be in sound health. Leverage continued to fall, while its ability to service its debt obligations showed improvement. Yet, despite this, private corporate investments remain depressed. Alongside, as household debt has continued to edge upwards — standing at 45.5 per cent by the end of September last year — it is a matter of concern that borrowing for consumption purposes, not asset creation, is the key driver of loans.

Uncertainty around West Asia persists. A deficient monsoon so far has impacted kharif sowing, while a strengthening El Niño may pose risks for the ensuing winter-spring rabi crop. Going by the prolonged food inflation during 2023-24, which was also an El Niño year, this could have implications for inflation and demand — between July 2023 and December 2024, food inflation averaged 8.5 per cent. These internal and external risks need close monitoring.

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THE UNITED STATES is reshaping its Asia strategy as it accepts that China can no longer be contained at an acceptable economic or military cost. This shift is reducing India’s strategic importance in Washington’s calculations while expanding US engagement across South Asia. As both the US and China compete for influence in India’s neighbourhood, New Delhi must act to preserve its strategic autonomy and rewire regional leadership.

The shift in American approach is driven by declining influence and a series of strategic setbacks. In Europe, the Ukraine war has imposed high financial and military costs on Washington, which now wants European nations to shoulder more of NATO’s burden. In the Middle East, the Iran war proved costly for the US. Iran was not subdued, while attacks on US bases in Gulf countries weakened confidence in America’s security guarantees and made close ties with Washington appear riskier for regional stability. Old US partners such as Saudi Arabia and the UAE are expanding ties with China.

In the Indo-Pacific, despite housing thousands of troops and maintaining military alliances with Japan, South Korea, Australia, and many ASEAN countries, and being part of frameworks such as the Quad and the Australia-UK-US Security Partnership, the US faces a different reality. China has become the largest trading partner for most economies in the region, and Asian manufacturing supply chains remain deeply tied to Chinese industry. This economic dependence has made many governments reluctant to fully align with US strategic objectives against Beijing. Malaysia’s Free Whatsapp Channel <https://whatsapp.com/channel/0029Van2VRb6RGJOKH6oBd0f>

withdrawal from the trade deal with the US is an example.

As Washington recognises these limits, its China strategy is changing. Instead of trying to contain Beijing, it increasingly appears to be treating China as a de facto equal — a G2 partner. In the Asia-Pacific, the US is seeking to preserve its influence without openly confronting China. It has become noticeably quieter on issues such as the Quad and Taiwan to avoid provoking Beijing.

Washington’s view of India is also undergoing a shift. For nearly two decades, India was central to Washington’s Indo-Pacific strategy and the Quad was a democratic counterweight to China. However, Washington now sees India not as a key strategic partner but more as a large market for American goods and technology and a subordinate partner. The February 7 US-India joint statement calls for India to align its economic and security interests more closely with those of America. Strategic co-operation is increasingly giving way to greater US strategic influence over India.

The US now appears to be following China’s playbook by expanding its engagement across South Asia. China has spent more than a decade building its “string of pearls” through ports, infrastructure financing and connectivity projects in countries around India. Its regional presence now includes the China-Pakistan Economic Corridor, Gwadar Port, Hambantota Port, Colombo Port City, Belt and Road projects in Nepal, major investments in Bangladesh and infrastructure projects across the Maldives.

Rather than treating South



AJAY SRIVASTAVA

Asia as India’s natural sphere of influence, Washington is deepening defence, maritime, digital and infrastructure cooperation with Bangladesh, Sri Lanka, Nepal and the Maldives. The appointment of Sergio Gor as both US Ambassador to India and Special Envoy for South and Central Asia reinforces the impression that Washington increasingly views South Asia as an integrated strategic space rather than through an India-centric lens.

This competition will give Bangladesh, Nepal, Sri Lanka and the Maldives greater leverage to play India, China and the US against one another to extract economic and political concessions.

Both Washington and Beijing also have an interest in keeping Pakistan strategically relevant as a counterweight to India. Pakistan has positioned itself as a swing state by maintaining close ties with the US, China, Saudi Arabia, Qatar, Turkey and Iran. As the world’s only nuclear-armed Muslim country, it holds growing strategic value in West Asia. Its ability to engage both Sunni states (Saudi Arabia, Qatar, the United Arab Emirates, Kuwait and Turkey) and Shia states (primarily Iran) further strengthens its regional influence. As the US and China view Pakistan as an important partner, India’s strategic environment becomes more challenging.

While India’s trade surplus with South Asia has grown from about US\$6.7 billion to nearly US\$20 billion over the past two decades, its political and strategic challenges remain. SAARC is largely dysfunctional, and relations with Bangladesh, Nepal and the Maldives con-

tinue to fluctuate. Pakistan is a failed state thriving on external steroids. Intensifying US-China competition is likely to deepen these challenges.

India cannot stop great-power rivalry in South Asia, but must avoid becoming an object of external power-politics. The playbook is simple. India must strengthen its economic base by prioritising manufacturing, artificial intelligence, semiconductors, critical minerals, defence production, and other advanced industries, while reducing its dependence on imported industrial inputs from China.

It should preserve strategic autonomy by keeping relations with both Washington and Beijing transactional and judging each issue on its merits. India must build connectivity projects, more responsive development partnerships and consistent political engagement with most neighbours.

Finally, India must avoid actions that create confusion about its longstanding positions. For example, India has consistently rejected third-party mediation with Pakistan, as it did by dismissing US President Donald Trump’s claim of mediation during Operation Sindoor. It should therefore avoid forums that invite outside powers into South Asian affairs. India’s high-level participation in the June 25–26 South Asia Dialogue in Colombo, alongside representatives from Pakistan, the US, the UK, Sri Lanka and the Maldives, blurred that position.

At a time when both Washington and Beijing are expanding their influence in South Asia, India should avoid actions that could be seen as accepting a larger role for external powers in its neighbourhood.

The writer is founder, GTRI

PPP 2.0 should focus on matching capital to risk



ARVIND MAYARAM

TWENTY YEARS ago, I was among those involved in developing India’s public-private partnership (PPP) framework. It transformed airports, highways and ports, but also produced stressed assets following the global financial crisis and the domestic slowdown. As confidence waned, public capital expenditure replaced PPPs as the principal model for financing infrastructure. That retreat was understandable. It was also a mistake.

Today, India faces a challenge far greater than the one we confronted two decades ago. By March 2025, the infrastructure pipeline had expanded to more than 13,000 projects with an aggregate value approaching Rs 185 lakh crore. Yet this is only a fraction of what will be required as India pursues the goal of becoming a developed economy by 2047. Simultaneously, it must finance the green transition — renewable energy, transmission, green hydrogen, climate-resilient cities and adaptation infrastructure. Recent estimates suggest that achieving net zero could require investments exceeding \$20 trillion by 2070. No country has financed a transformation of this scale without mobilising vast pools of private capital. India’s leading corporates will develop and operate many of these assets, but their balance sheets cannot finance investments of this magnitude. India needs not merely more capital, but a fundamentally different financing architecture. The central lesson from the first generation of PPPs is not that partnerships failed. It is that the financing model failed.

Infrastructure assets generate economic value for 30-50 years. Yet many PPP projects were financed through bank loans with repayment schedules of just 7-10 years. Projects therefore carried their heaviest debt-service burden when revenues were most uncertain. When growth slowed after 2008, revenues underperformed while debt obligations remained fixed, contributing to rising NPAs and undermining confidence in the model.

The central flaw was simple: Long-lived assets were financed with short-lived capital. The challenge today is no longer merely capital scarcity. It is capital circulation — matching the right capital to the right risk at the right stage of a project’s life cycle.

Governments are uniquely placed to finance high-risk phases such as project preparation, land acquisition and construction.

But once projects stabilise, scarce public capital should not remain locked in mature assets. Ownership and financing should progressively migrate to investors whose liabilities match long-duration infrastructure.

The opportunity is enormous. Global pension funds, insurance companies and sovereign wealth funds control more than \$110 trillion, much of it seeking stable, inflation-linked, long-term returns. India has already created the building blocks. InvITs have emerged as credible investment vehicles, while the National Investment and Infrastructure Fund has demonstrated the ability to attract global institutional capital. What is missing is a mechanism through which government capital, developer capital and institutional capital can continuously replace one another as project risks decline.

This is where circular finance becomes relevant. Government-supported finance and developers should fund projects through construction. Once revenues stabilise, InvITs should acquire operational assets, allowing governments and developers to recycle capital into new projects. As risks decline further, high-cost bank debt should be refinanced through infrastructure debt funds and ultimately held by pension funds, insurance companies and other long-term investors. The cost of capital should decline as project risks decline. Today’s financing architecture often does the opposite.

That is why the RBI should mandate dynamic risk-based repricing of infrastructure loans. Banks currently retain construction-stage risk premia long after projects have been de-risked, removing incentives for refinancing and capital recycling. Equally important is reviving infrastructure debt funds as the bridge between operational infrastructure and long-term institutional investors.

Every rupee locked indefinitely in a mature infrastructure asset is a rupee unavailable for financing the next highway, transmission line or renewable-energy project. The first generation of PPPs sought to mobilise private capital. The second must ensure that the same capital finances successive generations of infrastructure. In an economy that must build, decarbonise and maintain fiscal discipline, capital circulation may prove as important as capital mobilisation.

The writer is former finance secretary, Government of India

The opportunity is enormous. Global pension funds, insurance companies and sovereign wealth funds control more than \$110 trillion, much of it seeking stable, inflation-linked, long-term returns

The Ideas Page

THURSDAY, JULY 2, 2026

India's cotton farms need better soil, not just new GM seeds



KESHAV KRANTHI

THE ARTICLE by Ashok Gulati, Ayushi Gupta, and Ritika Juneja ('In cotton fields, policy is undoing what science built', IE, June 8) reads more like an advocacy piece for the seed industry than a balanced analysis of what ails Indian cotton. The authors credit Bt cotton, especially Bollgard-II, for the 88 per cent productivity increase between 2002 and 2013. They then argue that seed price control decisions killed the introduction of new GM events, including BG-II RRFlex and Bollgard-III, causing a decline in production and productivity since 2014-15. Had India continued its earlier trajectory, they claim, production would have reached 65.3 million bales by 2026, implying a productivity of 967 kg/ha. This diagnosis is flawed.

The authors appear to believe that GM seed technology alone drove India's productivity gains, and that approving BG-II RRFlex, Bollgard-III or the seven-gene Thryvon stack would restore that trajectory. Neither premise is supported by evidence. BG-II and BG-III protect crops against bollworm damage; RRFlex enables better weed management. These traits are agronomically useful, but there is no credible evidence from anywhere in the world that any of these traits directly increased yields. Framing GM trait approvals as the primary lever for productivity recovery deflects attention from the agronomic, soil science, breeding and management interventions that are decisive for sustainable yield improvement.

The authors compare India's yields of 441 kg/ha with China's 2,311 kg/ha and credit technology adoption for the difference. But China grows neither BG-III nor HT cotton nor Thryvon. It deploys exactly the same BG-II, Bt genes as India. The critical difference is that China grows Bt varieties rather than Bt hybrids.

The authors also omit a telling counterexample. Turkey has not approved GM cotton, yet its yields rose from 1,100 kg/ha in 1999 to 1,728 kg/ha in 2026. Over the same period, India's yields rose from 304 kg/ha to 458 kg/ha — they peaked at 566 kg/ha in 2013-14 and then declined. Turkey, without any approved GM variety, now achieves yields nearly four times that of India, whose cotton area is almost entirely planted with GM hybrids. China and Turkey offer compelling evidence that sustained productivity improvement depends on varietal development, agronomic investment and soil health, not trait approvals.

Data from the Ministry of Textiles also complicates the authors' narrative. India's productivity had already reached 521 kg/ha in 2006 and 554 kg/ha in 2007, when BG-II was approved, but occupied only a negligible share of cotton area, as seed production and distribution had yet to scale.

Crediting BG-II with the gains is not defensible. Productivity then declined to 449 kg/ha by 2018, even as BG-II adoption peaked. The productivity gains of 2002-2011 are better explained by a confluence of factors: Effective bollworm control by Bt cotton, hybrid seed adoption surging from 38 per cent to 92 per cent, fertiliser use increasing 2.3-fold, and irrigated area expanding from 2.5 million to 4.4 million hectares. Heavier farmer investment in crop management compounded these gains. Once inputs approached saturation, it was the law of diminishing returns, not seed price policy, that drove decline.

The root cause of India's cotton productivity collapse goes unmentioned in the article. According to FAO, nearly 32 per cent of Indian land is degraded and 25 per cent faces desertification. Soil organic carbon in Indian croplands averages just 0.3-0.6 per cent, far below the globally accepted minimum of 1-1.5 per cent for productive soils, with critically low levels below 0.25 per cent recorded across cotton-growing regions of Rajasthan, Gujarat, Madhya Pradesh and Maharashtra. No technology stack, GM or otherwise, can deliver its yield potential in soils this depleted.

The primary focus of the Cotton Technology Mission should be restoring soil organic carbon through regenerative agriculture, particularly biochar-compost systems combined with farming-system-specific high-density plant spacing geometries. The mission must also prioritise climate-resilient varieties, improving ginning outturn from 33 per cent to the global average of 39 per cent, raising harvest index from 30 per cent to 50 per cent to improve input-use efficiency, smallholder mechanisation, sustainable pink bollworm management, and reducing input costs that disadvantage farmers.

India need not refuse new GM technologies, but approving them will not, by itself, move the needle. The transformation Indian cotton needs will come from better climate-resilient varieties, healthier soils, and better agronomy. That is what the Cotton Technology Mission must be built to deliver.

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The writer is chief scientist, International Cotton Advisory Committee (ICAC). The views are personal and do not represent ICAC's positions



ILLUSTRATION: TANUSHRI MITRA



SANGMUAN HANGSING

THREE YEARS after violence first engulfed Manipur, many people can tell you which roads to avoid. They know which journeys require extra planning, which routes feel familiar, and which places are no longer visited as casually as before. Students who once crossed district lines to attend schools and colleges often make different choices today. Traders who depended upon customers from multiple communities increasingly operate within narrower networks. Families visiting relatives think about travel in ways that would have seemed unusual before May 2023.

This knowledge emerged gradually

through caution, and experience. After three years, it has become woven into everyday routines, shaping decisions about where people travel, study, work, and whom they encounter along the way.

When violence first erupted, most people assumed that the arrangements created in response to it would remain temporary. Communities retreated into areas where they felt secure, and movement became more difficult. Security forces were deployed across large parts of the state. Institutions struggled to function normally. The expectation was that these disruptions, however severe, would eventually recede. But over time, people adjusted their routines, journeys, and relationships around them, gradually incorporating them into everyday life.

Relative periods of calm have not al-

ways produced a corresponding sense of peace. The number of violent incidents may decline while the habits formed in response to them remain largely unchanged. By the time these become routine, they no longer feel like responses to a crisis. They linger in daily decisions and become part of how life is organised.

Ongoing tensions involving the Naga

Three years ago, many of the adjustments demanded by the conflict were understood as emergency responses to an extraordinary situation. Today, some have lasted long enough to become part of the social landscape

Free Whatsapp Channel <https://whatsapp.com/channel/0029Van2VRb6RGJOKH6oBd0F> and Kuki communities illustrate how quickly separation can reinforce itself. The immediate priority lies in preventing further violence and ensuring accountability. Yet every confrontation leaves behind new calculations about safety, movement, and trust. Existing suspicions acquire fresh reasons to persist. Journeys that once seemed routine require greater caution, while interactions that once occurred naturally become less frequent.

Recent violence has brought additional COBRA units into the state. Few would question the need to protect vulnerable communities or prevent further escalation. However, after three years, the pattern has become familiar: Every fresh crisis is followed by another deployment, another operation, and another effort to restore order. Such measures can secure

roads and reduce violence. They cannot undo the routines that prolonged conflict leaves behind.

Three years ago, many of the adjustments demanded by the conflict were understood as emergency responses to an extraordinary situation. Today, some have lasted long enough to become part of the social landscape. Whether these fade or endure will depend in part on the recovery of the institutions and encounters that once brought different communities into routine contact. The longer that recovery remains incomplete, the more difficult it becomes to distinguish between temporary adjustments and the habits a society learns to live with.

Hansing is a researcher and writer based out of Manipur

• HEALTH AND POLICY

Why eggs matter for schoolkids

Different foods serve distinct nutritional purposes. But from the lens of nutrition science, the egg remains one of the most complete and easy-to-prepare foods



EXPERT EXPLAINS

DR SEEMA GULATI

HEAD, NUTRITION RESEARCH GROUP, AT NATIONAL DIABETES, OBESITY AND CHOLESTEROL FOUNDATION, DELHI

AT A time when several states continue to debate whether eggs should be part of school midday meals, West Bengal has pulled them out. The discussion often centres on culture, ideology or personal food choices. Lost in that debate is a fundamental question: What does science say?

For millions of Indian children, especially those from low-income households, the midday meal may be their most nutritious meal of the day. Decisions about what goes on that plate must, therefore, be guided by evidence. And the evidence on eggs — as a source of complete, affordable and highly bioavailable protein (which is well-utilised by the body upon consumption) — is difficult to ignore.

All nutritional guidelines suggest that 10-35% of our daily calories should come from protein-rich foods. Protein is also necessary for building lean mass, burning fat, increasing metabolism, slowing blood sugar release, and helping the body repair itself. However, “the issue is not just of protein from animal or plant sources. The most important one is, how much of that protein can the body actually use,” **Dr Seema Gulati**, Head, Nutrition Research Group at the National Diabetes, Obesity and Cholesterol (N-DOC) Foundation, Delhi, tells **Rinku Ghosh**. N-DOC is a non-profit that partners with the Indian Council of Medical Research to research and prevent metabolic diseases.

The answer begins not with grams of protein, but with amino acids, the tiny building blocks of life from which every muscle fibre, hormone, enzyme and immune cell is made. The human body requires 20 amino acids, of which 11 can be manufactured internally. The remaining nine must come entirely from food. “A food that supplies all nine in adequate proportions is called a complete protein. Eggs are among the very few natural foods that do precisely that, hence they have been a part of midday meal schemes. Those who cannot have eggs need a mix of plant proteins for equivalence,” Gulati adds. Here, she explains why eggs are often seen as the gold standard for protein intake, and what it takes to match their nutritional profile for people who don’t consume them.

Protein: Quantity vs quality

Consider the numbers (*see box*). A hundred grams in terms of real meals means two boiled eggs, a two-thirds cup of cooked soyabean and more than a cup of paneer chunks. In this scenario, cooked soyabeans contain 13.23 g of protein, almost identical to the 13.43 g found in two boiled eggs. Paneer provides 18.9 g, while whole milk contributes 3.3-3.7 g.

Judged solely by protein content, eggs and cooked soyabeans appear virtually indistinguishable. But proteins are not all created equal. Egg protein naturally contains all nine essential amino acids in proportions remarkably close to human requirements. It is also highly digestible, allowing the body to absorb and utilise it more efficiently compared to other foods. This bioavailability is why eggs have long served as the international reference protein against which the quality of other proteins is assessed.

Plant proteins tell a more complex story. Soyabean is undoubtedly among the highest-quality plant proteins available

and comes closer than most plant foods to providing a balanced amino acid profile. Yet, like other plant proteins, it is best viewed as part of a dietary mix rather than a standalone solution.

Nutritionists, therefore, recommend combining legumes with cereals — *dal* with rice, *rajma* with rice, *khichdi*, *roti* with *chana*, or millets with pulses — so that one food compensates for the amino acids another supplies in smaller amounts. For vegetarians, this principle of protein complementation is fundamental with legumes, dairy and nuts. An egg, by contrast, has that balance already built in.

Plant proteins may seem inadequate individually. But they achieve their full nutritional potential through intelligent combinations. Cereals and pulses complement one another. Dairy and soy enrich the overall amino acid profile. Apart from combinations, there are always fortified foods.

The ‘brain nutrient’ factor

Choline is a nutrient that receives far less public attention than protein, despite being indispensable for brain development, memory, nerve signalling and liver health. Whole milk provides around 14-16 mg of choline per 100 g. Paneer contains roughly 15-20 mg, while cooked soyabean offers about 44-45 mg. Eggs provide 290-300 mg of choline. In simple terms, eggs contain almost seven times more choline than cooked soyabeans and nearly 20 times more than milk or paneer.

Each food has its own strength

Each food brings something valuable to the table. Cooked soyabeans are an excellent source of dietary fibre (792 g), iron (2.88 mg), magnesium (66.1 mg) and potassium (571.9 mg). It also contributes useful amounts of thiamine, niacin and folate, making it one of the strongest plant-based protein foods available.

Paneer stands out for its 18.9 g of protein and its exceptionally high calcium content (476 mg per 100 g), making it an important food for bone health. It also contributes phosphorus, zinc and biotin in meaningful amounts.

Milk remains one of the most accessible sources of calcium, riboflavin and high-quality dairy nutrition.

A boiled egg provides high-quality complete protein, meaningful amounts of riboflavin, pantothenic acid, biotin, phosphorus, iron and zinc, together with one of the richest natural sources of choline, all within a single, compact food.

Carbohydrates and fats

The accompanying fats and carbohydrates also determine how a food fits into a balanced diet. Per 100 g, boiled eggs contain 10.54 g of fat and virtually no carbohydrates, making them naturally suited to diets that prioritise high-quality protein. Cooked soyabeans provide 6.79 g of fat, 3.57 g of carbohydrates, and an additional 792 g of dietary fibre, offering a combination of plant protein, complex carbs and fibre that supports sustained energy release.

For the same quantity, paneer contains the highest fat content (14.8 g) among the foods compared, together with 12.4 g of carbohydrates, reflecting its energy-dense nature. Milk, meanwhile, remains the lightest option, contributing 4.5-6.6 g of fat and 4.9-8.3 g of carbohydrates, depending on whether it is cow’s or buffalo’s milk.

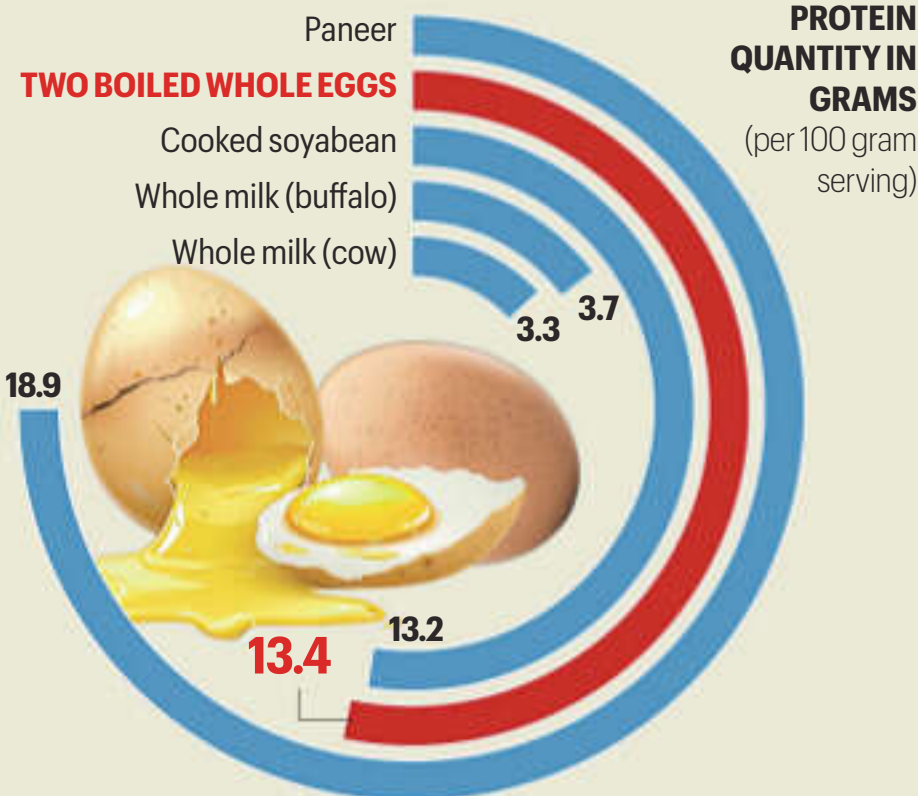
These differences illustrate that while eggs stand out for their complete protein and micronutrient density, soyabeans contribute valuable fibre and plant nutrients, paneer offers concentrated dairy nutrition, and milk provides a balanced everyday source of energy and nutrients. Each food serves a distinct nutritional purpose rather than competing on a single parameter. But from the lens of nutrition science, the humble egg continues to hold its place as one of the most complete and easy-to-prepare foods.

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• EGGS vs THE REST

The chart and table show the quantity of nutrients such as protein and carbohydrates in various foods.

- Eggs and cooked soyabeans appear indistinguishable in protein content. But not all proteins are created equal.
- Eggs are highly digestible and ‘bio-available’ (well-utilised by the body).
- Soyabean is a high-quality plant protein. But it is best as part of a dietary mix rather than a standalone solution.
- Paneer has higher protein. But 100 gms is tough to consume at one go. Egg also contains all nine essential amino acids.



(NUTRIENT VALUES BELOW ARE PER 100 GRAM SERVING)					
	Whole milk (buffalo)	Whole milk (cow)	Paneer (cottage cheese)	Cooked soyabean	Two boiled whole eggs
Energy (gram)	107.3	72.9	257.9	132.09	147.7
Carbohydrate (g)	8.3	4.9	12.4	3.57	Virtually nil
Fats (g)	6.6	4.5	14.8	6.79	10.54
Calcium (milligram)	121	118	476	68.25	55.1
Riboflavin (B2) (mg)	0.13	0.11	0.1	0.08	0.19

DATA COMPILED BY DR SEEMA GULATI

A lesson from Tamil Nadu, pioneer in midday meals



ANAGHA JAYAKUMAR

THE WEST Bengal government has announced that it will remove eggs from midday meals, sparking a debate over what children should be served in school.

The decision has prompted comparisons with Tamil Nadu, which, as Madras Presidency, pioneered the concept of midday meals in India, and has provided eggs under its programme for decades now. Tamil Nadu’s midday meal scheme has evolved over a century, with governments revisiting what children should be fed, and why.

Getting children into school...

Chief minister K Kamaraj is often credited with introducing a school meal programme in Madras State in 1956. But he had built on decades of experiments within the pre-independence Madras Presidency to get children into schools.

The first publicly funded school meal experiment in Madras Presidency began in 1920 as part of an effort to expand compulsory elementary education.

Officials recognised that poverty, hunger and families’ dependence on children’s earnings kept many children out of school. They also realised that compulsory education could not be achieved through coercive tactics alone. Against this backdrop, the Madras Corporation turned to school meals as an incentive to attract and retain children in classrooms, writes historian Catriona Ellis in her 2023 book *Imagining Childhood, Improving Children: The Emergence of an ‘Avuncular’ State in Late Colonial South India*.

By most accounts, Justice Party president P Theagaraya Chetty, also president of Madras Corporation Council, backed a midday meal scheme to benefit the state’s impoverished children. The pilot was at a corporation school in Madras city in 1920.

The daily cost per head was capped at one anna. Yet the scheme quickly proved its value. In *Imagining Childhood, Improving Children*, Ellis notes that attendance reportedly dropped by 50% when the scheme was briefly suspended in 1927.

By the end of the decade, the debate had

How school lunch came to other states

• In 1984, Kerala became the country’s second state to have a school lunch programme.

• Over the next few years, many other states launched their own versions of the scheme, and finally in 1995, the Centre stepped in. It was launched as a centrally sponsored scheme across 2,408 blocks for students up to Class 5, initially providing foodgrains to states.

• In 2001, following a landmark Supreme Court order, states were directed to provide cooked mid-day meals rather than dry rations. In 2007, the UPA government expanded the scheme to Class 8.

• In 2021, the scheme was named PM POSHAN.

shifted from getting children into school to ensuring they could learn once they were there. In 1930, the Madras Corporation declared: “If you cannot feed the body of a child, you cannot feed the brain.” For Ellis, that shift was rooted in education rather than public health. “Hungry children can’t concentrate on learning; they might be in school but they can’t learn anything if they’re hungry,” she told *The Indian Express*.

...and keeping them there

By the 1930s, education authorities in Madras increasingly treated children’s health as central to their educational mission, Ellis writes. Corporation debates increasingly focused on the nutritional value of school meals, the need for a balanced diet and the quality of food provided to children. Officials debated whether bread and milk were preferable to the usual rice-and-curd diet, but also whether children should be served food familiar to them.

“The key conclusion was that it was more important to provide food that the children would like and eat, than to focus on the most efficient or nutritious food,” Ellis told *The Indian Express*. “Providing food similar to what the children would have eaten at home seems to be a way of helping school feel familiar and safe, and therefore a place to learn.”

Medical inspection increasingly accompanied school meals, reinforcing the idea that schools were responsible not only for education but also for nutrition and physical development. This marked a wider shift in how the state viewed children.

However, this political concern did not always translate into adequate funding.

Eggs in the basket

The next milestone came after Independence, when chief minister Kamaraj expanded the school meal programme in 1956. The scheme was transformed under chief minister MG Ramachandran’s Nutrition Meal Programme in 1982, which placed greater emphasis on nutritional needs alongside improving attendance.

In January 1989, chief minister M Karunanidhi announced that children under the scheme would receive one boiled egg every two weeks. Successive governments expanded the frequency of egg distribution and the menu itself. In 2013, Chief Minister J Jayalithaa introduced the Variety Meals scheme to expand the nutritional value and appeal of the midday meal programme.

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without regard to the rest of the world. The war stands as a rare instance — the first since the 1956 Suez war — in which a Middle Eastern nation has directly faced off with one of the world’s foremost military powers, stood its ground, and compelled the adversary to negotiate on balanced terms. That boosts Iran’s position in the Islamic world and strengthens the hands of the Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps.

Outlook for oil and gas markets

While price forecasts are logical determinations based on supply and demand projections, market prices are based on sentiments of traders whose job is to match demand with supply, and make money. During the last four months, market prices have remained consistently below forecasts, indicating optimism which may, fortunately, be borne out. But optimism and pessimism are no substitutes for planning. Oil prices could have easily gone in the

opposite direction had there been no MoU and had the Strait remained closed for much longer. The world’s economy has had a close shave in terms of energy security. And we are by no means out of the woods yet. Oil prices have fallen back but do not represent a return to the pre-war situation.

Disruptions to negotiations and outbursts of fighting may cause volatility in the coming months. The power balance in the Persian Gulf stands fundamentally altered, reducing its reliability as an energy supplier. Changes in the energy policies of consuming nations will be needed.

Meanwhile, it would be wise to top off oil, liquefied petroleum gas, liquefied natural gas, and fertiliser stocks and expand reserves, taking advantage of reduced prices. Reserves cost money but insure against much worse economic damage and social unrest from physical scarcity.

FULL REPORT ON www.indianexpress.com

• GEOPOLITICS

US-Iran talks: ‘MoU is a breakthrough for Iran, but overreach would be folly’



EXPERT EXPLAINS

AJAY SINGH

TOKYO-BASED ENERGY & SHIPPING EXECUTIVE

AFTER TRADING strikes over the past week, the US and Iran appear to be finally inching back towards the negotiating table. These strikes had threatened to unravel a fragile truce between both countries that remains in place despite occasional flare-ups and Israeli aggression in southern Lebanon.

Last month, a 14-point Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) was signed as part of a framework agreement to end the war

in West Asia that began in February. **Ajay Singh**, a management advisor and a former oil and gas industry executive with considerable experience of the Middle East, spoke to **Anil Sasi** about how the situation could have unfolded differently in the absence of an MoU or had the Strait remained closed for much longer.

Prospects for US-Iran talks

Flare-ups may continue as the MoU has left crucial details unaddressed, such as arrangements for monitoring and enforcing the ceasefire in Lebanon, protocols for shipping in the Strait, and whether or not the International Atomic Energy Agency’s inspectors may access sites in Iran.

Some people on both sides may prefer that full-blown fighting resumes, and cause disruptions in Lebanon or the Strait as elections in Israel and the US draw closer. But the US and Iran will likely get on with negotiations because both realise that further con-

flict is not in their interests, at least for now. Mutual mistrust and the complexity of the nuclear issue make it highly unlikely that a result will be forthcoming within 60 days — if at all — and extensions will be required. The best outcome would be something like the Joint Comprehensive Plan of Action (JCPOA) of 2015, whereby Iran may pursue a peaceful nuclear programme under safeguards and secure a lasting end to sanctions, in return for the highly enriched uranium being rendered harmless.

Perhaps the US — although not Israel — may be amenable to such a deal, so long as it can be presented as an improvement over the JCPOA.

This is an opportunity for Iran to make peace with dignity, secure the rightful future prosperity of its people, and end its decades-long ostracisation. The unknown is the internal dynamic within the Iranian regime at this time. It may well decide that the country’s only guarantee of security lies

in continued conflict, or insist on a complete withdrawal of US forces from the Middle East. That would be an overreach.

The situation after the US mid-term elections may not be quite as favourable for Iran; the military advantage that it has secured through the use of drones and missiles will eventually be countered; and in a no-holds-barred conflict, superior American economic and technological strength will prevail.

Significance of the MoU

One may say that Iran has pulled off something of a breakthrough. After decades of enduring tough sanctions, it has restored its primary source of national income through oil export in addition to securing access to hitherto frozen funds, besides another \$300 billion of funding. It retains the military capabilities to continue menacing adversaries and choke off the Strait of Hormuz. Extraordinarily, the US has recognised Iran’s claims over the Strait,

GST COLLECTIONS HAD HIT A RECORD HIGH OF RS 2.43 LAKH CRORE IN APRIL

GST mop up in June rose by 14%, revenue from imports soared 35%

Siddharth Upasani
New Delhi, July 1

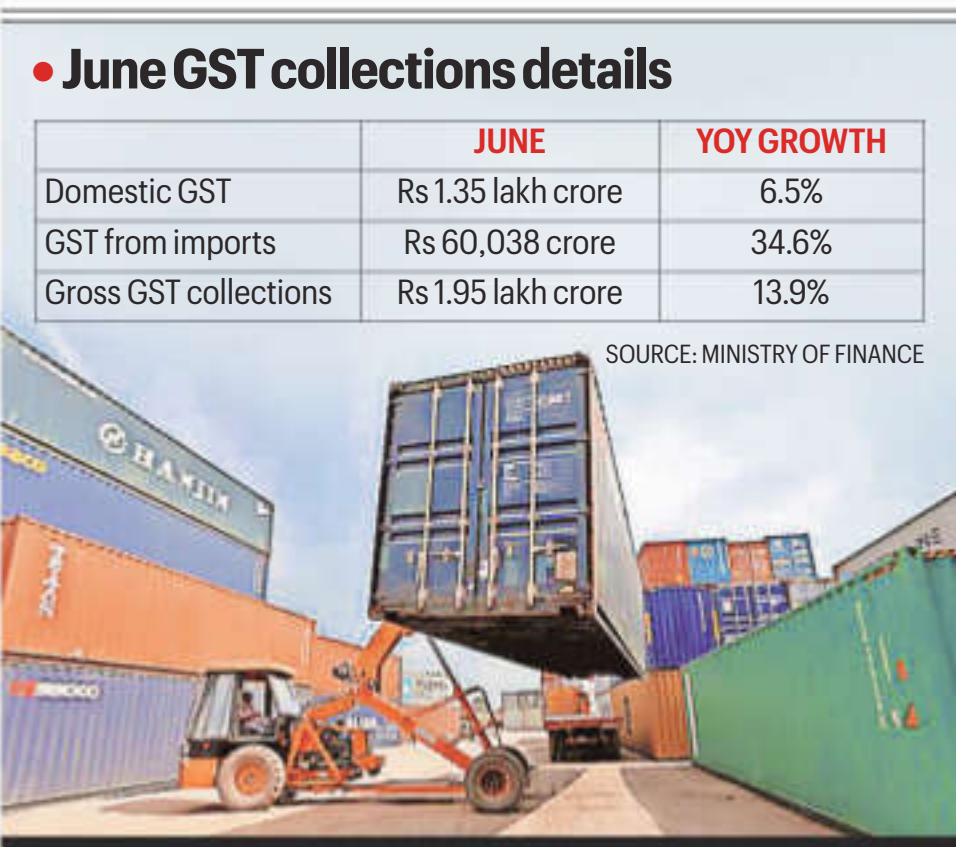
THE CENTRE collected Rs 1.95 lakh crore as Goods and Services Tax (GST) on a gross basis in June, up 13.9% from last year, buoyed by a 34.6% rise in tax revenue from imports — almost double the 19.1% increase seen in May.

According to data released by the Ministry of Finance on Wednesday, the June GST collections were only marginally higher than the Rs 1.94 lakh crore mopped-up in May.

GST collections had hit a record high of Rs 2.43 lakh crore in April. In June, domestic revenue accounted for 69.2% — or Rs 1.35 lakh crore — of the gross GST collections as it rose 6.5% year-on-year, with the remaining 30.8% amounting to Rs 60,038 crore came from imports. In May, GST from imports had made up 30.7% of total collections, with government sources arguing then that the rise in Integrated GST revenue from imports was a sign of “industrial capacity expansion”.

Officials had said the 19.1% rise in GST from imports in May was driven by inbound shipments of raw materials and intermediate inputs that feed India’s industrial production

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Free Telegram Channel https://t.me/+2RvD_RGF9mljMzg1
Indian economy amidst geopolitical uncertainties”.

Meanwhile, Ikesh Nagpal, Lead-Indirect Tax at tax and consulting firm AKM Global, said it was “encouraging” that the growth in GST collections was alongside a 29.1% increase in refunds. This, according to Nagpal, indicated that “strong revenue growth is being achieved without affecting liquidity for businesses”.

Total refunds in June rose to Rs 32,436 crore, resulting in net GST revenue being 11.2% higher at Rs 1.62 lakh crore. Net do-

mestic revenue was only 2.6% higher from last year at Rs 1.17 lakh crore, while net revenue from imports was 42.2% higher at Rs 45,370 crore.

The data for June came on the same day the GST began its 10th year of existence, having been rolled out on July 1, 2017. The new indirect tax regime continues to be fine-tuned, with the GST Council last year in September approving a raft of changes, including lower tax rates and a two-slab structure, among others.

Experts continue to expect more reforms in the GST system, with BDO India’s Karthik Mani, Partner & Leader (South) – Indirect Tax, saying that industry and taxpayers want a single pan-India GST registration “to end the compliance burden of state-wise registrations”. Other changes on the wish-list include a “genuine amnesty” for routine reconciliation mismatches so taxpayers are not dragged into litigation over minor notices, auto-populated monthly returns to reduce manual filing to near-zero, and fungibility of Input Tax Credit across states. “Achieving these would mark GST’s true transition from a tax reform to a genuinely frictionless, taxpayer-first system,” Mani said.

Manufacturing activity cools in June: PMI data

New Delhi: India’s manufacturing sector activity growth eased in June, as new business orders and international sales increased at softer rates, resulting in slower expansions in buying levels, employment and output, a monthly survey said on Wednesday.

The seasonally adjusted HSBC India Manufacturing Purchasing Managers’ Index fell from 55.0 in May to 54.2 in June, pointing to the second-weakest improvement in the health of the sector since mid-2022. The HSBC India Manufacturing Purchasing Managers’ Index (PMI) is a gauge of overall conditions derived from measures of new orders, output, employment, supplier delivery times and stocks of purchases. A print above 50 means expansion, while a score below 50 denotes contraction. Several firms reported an improvement in demand conditions, but others noted subdued client appetite for their products and fierce market competition. PTI

New EPF scheme notified: Most core provisions retained

ENS Economic Bureau
New Delhi, July 1

THE CENTRE has notified the Employees’ Provident Fund Scheme, 2026, retaining most of the core provisions — including the 12% contribution rate, eligibility norms and withdrawal framework — of the Employees’ Provident Fund Scheme, 1952, while aligning the provident fund framework with the Code on Social Security, 2020.

The new scheme focuses on simplifying procedures, strengthening governance, expanding digital compliance and easing the transition to the labour codes. Most fundamental features of the EPF system, including contribution rates, eligibility and benefit structure, remain intact, offering continuity for both employers and employees.

“The new Employees’ Provident Fund Scheme, 2026 represents a major milestone in the next phase of implementing the labour codes,” said Puneet Gupta, Partner, People Advisory Services, EY India. “Coming into effect immediately, it modernises the provident fund framework through greater digitalisation, simplified processes and enhanced compliance requirements for both employers and employees.”

For employees, one key change is the simplification of withdrawal rules.

Members will be able to make partial withdrawals under streamlined procedures for essential needs such as illness, education, marriage and housing requirements. FE

Public funds clause reinstated in RBI’s upper layer NBFCs

ENS Economic Bureau
Mumbai, July 1

THE RESERVE Bank of India (RBI) on Wednesday reinstated a key definition on public funds in its revised guidelines for core investment companies (CICs) and upper layer NBFCs.

The move keeps Tata Sons’ prospects of avoiding a mandatory stock market listing tied to the central bank’s decision on its application to surrender its CIC licence.

The RBI had originally defined indirect receipt of public funds in a circular issued on April 29 as “funds received not directly but through associates and group entities which have access to public funds.”

The definition was omitted from the central bank’s June 24 circular but reinstated in a footnote in an updated version released on Wednesday, effective July 1, 2026.

Although Tata Sons has had no direct access to public funds since repaying its debt in 2024, it remains an indirect recipient of public funds under the RBI’s definition because listed Tata companies, including Tata Steel, Tata Chemicals, and Tata Power, hold equity stakes in it.

The RBI came out with revised guidelines last week stating the requirement to qualify as Upper Layer non-banking finance companies (NBFC-UL) without giving clarity whether Tata Sons, the holding company of \$180 billion Tata group, will have to go public with an IPO or not.

The RBI’s final list of NBFC-UL — which is expected soon — and the qualifying assets are



Tata Sons remains an indirect recipient of public funds under the RBI’s definition, because listed Tata companies hold equity stakes in it. REUTERS

potentially very significant for Tata Sons as they could remove the main regulatory trigger that has kept alive the possibility of a mandatory IPO.

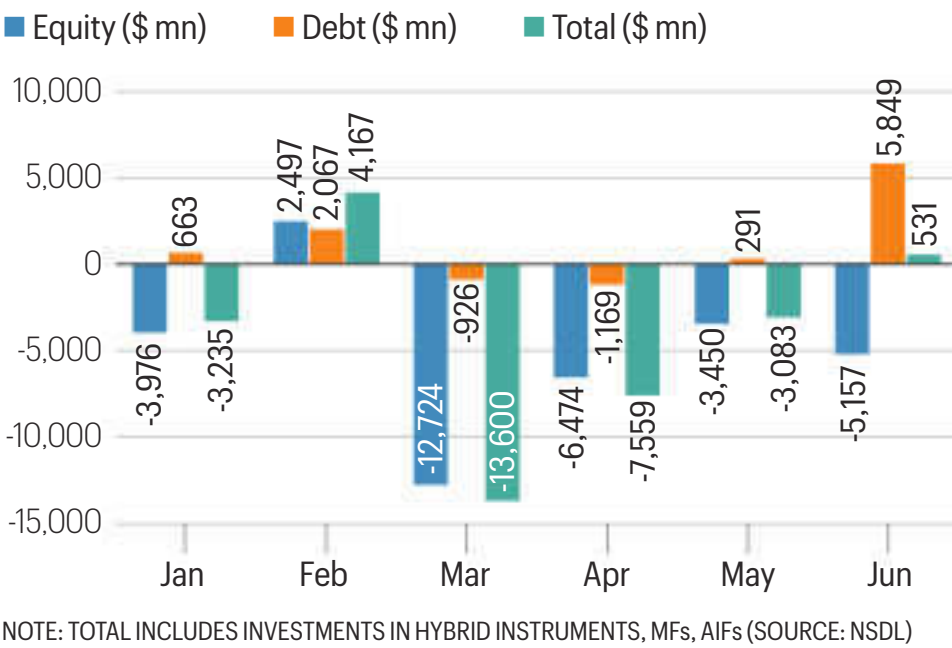
In 2024, the RBI classified Tata Sons as an Upper Layer NBFC (NBFC-UL) under its Scale-Based Regulation framework because of its size and systemic importance.

Under RBI rules, an NBFC-UL is required to list on a stock exchange within three years of being notified and comply with stricter governance and disclosure norms.

That classification effectively put Tata Sons on a path toward a public listing since September 2025, unless the RBI changed the rules or granted relief. Tata Trusts hold 66 per cent stake in Tata Sons.

● Is foreign investment tide turning for India?

For the first time in four months, June saw India post a positive number for net foreign portfolio investments (FPIs). While only \$531 million, it marks a turnaround after a total net outflow of \$24.2 billion over March, April, and May.



● The positive net FPI investment in June was down to the debt segment, with the measures to attract foreign funds in sovereign bonds paying immediate dividends. After FPI investment in debt of just \$291 million in May, the figure jumped to \$5.85 billion in June.

● Outflows from equities, however, continued in June, rising to \$5.16

billion from \$3.45 billion in May.

● There has been a rebound even in terms of foreign direct investment (FDI), which jumped to \$15.29 billion in April — the highest since August 2020 — in gross terms, as per latest data. Even on a net basis, FDI was in positive territory for the fourth month in a row at \$6.58 billion, the highest since May 2021.

RBI Guv sees case for lower inflation target in long run

Mumbai: India is unlikely to raise its official inflation target and there may be a case for lowering it over the long term, Reserve Bank of India (RBI) Governor Sanjay Malhotra said at an event in Russia on Wednesday.

The country’s inflation-targeting framework has helped lower average inflation, the central bank chief said in a conversation with his Russian counterpart, Elvira Nabiullina. India adopted its inflation-targeting framework in 2016, which tasks the RBI with keeping inflation

within a band set by the government. In March, the government retained its retail inflation target of 4%, within its comfort band of 2%-6%, following a review.

The target will remain in place for five years. Speaking at the Financial Congress of the Bank of Russia, Malhotra said while inflation in India is expected to rise, it currently remains below the central bank’s target.

He added that he was confident the economy would continue growing at a fast pace for the foreseeable future. REUTERS